than factual recounting. Like Sebald and Cole, Thayil is interested in migration. What the act of leaving does to individuals. The artist, he says, "is the stranger, the perpetual outsider." Thayil's fidelity, simply put, is to a community. Of "elsewhereans", of peripatetic perspectives.

When I complained to Thayil about my own background, growing up and being educated in different places and circumstances, so that I have long felt a hole where cultural confidence should be, he said the "condition" I was describing "as a 'hole' is actually a whole, a condition that makes it possible to create in a specific way." Displacement, he argues, whether literal or metaphorical, is the contemporary state of being. It's what makes *The Elsewhereans* a deeply political book, a "rich evocation", as Amitav Ghosh calls it, "of decolonisation and non-alignment."

The lives of its protagonists are a rebuke of a global moment in which increasingly authoritarian governments are trying to define what it means to come from a place, what it means to be a citizen. Thayil's father, a reporter and editor, was arrested in Bihar, the "first editor in independent India to be charged with sedition". Today, notes the narrator, "the arrest of journalists and students under the charge of sedition is commonplace. Hardly worth remarking."

In this telling, the world is embroiled, perhaps always has been, in a battle between those who can empathise with and tell the stories of others and those who cannot make that leap of imagination. A storyteller's job is to put his audience in the minds of others, to take us elsewhere. For Thayil, this is a kind of internationalism that has long fallen out of fashion. Citizens of the world, as the former British prime minister Theresa May said in 2016, are "citizens of nowhere". One such citizen of nowhere would have been James Joyce, who exiled himself to Europe to write not just *Ulysses* but also *Dubliners*, needing to leave the city that occupied his every waking hour to write about it. In perhaps Joyce's most famous story, he concludes with an image of "snow falling faintly through the universe and faintly falling, like the descent of their last end, upon all the living and the dead".

Thayil's work is vividly specific, vividly Indian, yet it resonates elsewhere, everywhere, in fact, where people do not want to swallow the narrow, the parochial, the circumscribed ideologies, Thayil said, "being forced down their throats."

Home may be where the heart is, but our hearts are large. And home is also where the imagination can roam, can find the space to tell all our stories—as Thayil, arguably India's most experimental contemporary writer, reminds us—not just those the authorities deem acceptable. ■

—Shougat Dasgupta

THE LIVES OF THIS BOOK'S PROTAGONISTS ARE A REBUKE OF A GLOBAL MOMENT IN WHICH AUTHORITARIAN GOVERNMENTS ARE TRYING TO DEFINE WHAT IT MEANS TO BE A CITIZEN



Bahrain and Kuwait once upon a time all came under the British flag. Using oral histories, memoirs and rigorous historical documentation—Dalrymple provides a variety of voices to his nuanced narrative.

For me, it is the pre-Partition Burmese connection that remains the most interesting. I had always been fascinated that the global reach of the Empire meant that, in the 1900s, people from my village in Hoshiarpur, Punjab, also worked in Rangoon, Burma, in the timber and mining industry—leaving their farmlands behind. All this was to come to a halt on April 1, 1937, and, as Dalrymple records, newspaper headlines stated "Burma Divorces India". Aden, Yemen would also be partitioned from the Empire on April Fool's Day.

What followed would be escape and migration back to India for those who had chosen to make Burma their home—alas, it was a forgotten list of 600,000 refugees who fled in 1942 and around a lakh of them would not make it.

USING ***ORAL HISTORIES, MEMOIRS AND OLD DOCUMENTS,*** DALRYMPLE ADDS NUANCE TO THE PARTITION STORY

As someone who set up and runs two museums on the Partition of India—one appreciates the addition of an important new voice recording the many Partitions that took place in just the last hundred years. This is an ambitious, meticulously researched book that covers a lot of ground, and is much needed. ■

—Kishwar Desai